

Postmortem: Checkout Timeout Incident

Page 1 - Summary

On the incident date, checkout-service experienced elevated p99 latency and a spike in 5xx errors when calling payments-api under load.

Root Cause

Page 2 - Root Cause

payments-api calls from checkout-service were retried immediately on failure with no backoff delay, amplifying load on an already-degraded downstream service and extending the outage window.

Remediation

Page 3 - Remediation

checkout-service now wraps payments-api calls in an exponential backoff
retry policy: base_delay_ms=200, multiplier=2.0, max_retries=5, jitter=full.
A circuit breaker trips after 10 consecutive failures within 30s and
opens for 60s before allowing a half-open retry probe.

Result

Page 4 - Result

Post-deploy, p99 latency for checkout->payments dropped from 4200ms to 310ms and the error rate fell from 18% to under 1%, confirmed on the Grafana dashboard the following day.